8 Indian National Movement – Phase II (1918-1939)

Dawn of Gandhian Era

Mahatma Gandhi spent over **20 years in South Africa**, where he began his **Satyagraha experiments** and founded the newspaper **Indian Opinion**. He returned to India on **January 9, 1915**, and spent his first year traveling across the country to understand its conditions. In **1916**, he established the **Sabarmati Ashram** in Ahmedabad as a base for his work.

Gandhiji's Early Career and Truth Experiments in South Africa

- **Birth and Education:** Mohandas Karamchand Gandhi was born on **October 2, 1869**, in **Porbandar, Gujarat**, then part of the princely state of Kathiawar. His father served as **Diwan (minister)**. After studying **law in England**, Gandhi went to **South Africa in 1898** for a case involving his client **Dada Abdullah**.
- **Racial Discrimination in South Africa:** In South Africa, Gandhi witnessed severe **white racism** and the **humiliation of Asians**, especially Indian labourers. The Indian community comprised **indentured labourers**, mostly working on **sugar plantations**; **Meman Muslim merchants**; and **ex-indentured workers**. Most were **illiterate**, spoke little English, and accepted **racial discrimination** as a norm.

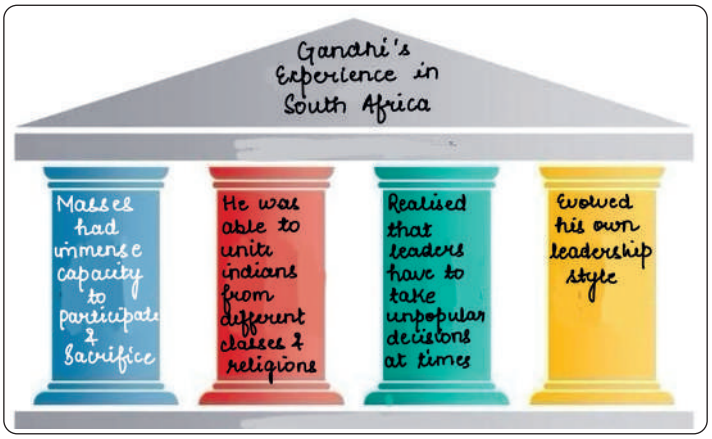

Fig. 8.1: Gandhi's Experience in South Africa
Diagram Type: *Pillar*

- **Imposed Disabilities:** Indians faced harsh restrictions—they were **denied voting rights**, forced to live in **overcrowded, unsanitary areas**, banned from **using public sidewalks**, and had **night curfews** similar to those imposed on Africans.
- **Organising Resistance:** Gandhi decided to stay in South Africa until **1914** to **organise Indian workers** and **fight for their civil rights**, marking the beginning of his experiments with **truth and Satyagraha**.

Gandhi's Moderate Struggle in South Africa (1894-1906)

- **Petitions and memorials:** During this phase, Gandhi relied on sending petitions and memorials to the authorities in South Africa and Britain.
- **To unite Indians:** He founded the Natal Indian Congress and began publishing Indian opinions in order to unite various groups of Indians.

Gandhi's Passive Resistance or Satyagraha in South Africa (1906-1914)

- **Satyagraha Against Registration Certificates (1906):** A new law in South Africa required Indians to carry registration certificates with their fingerprints at all times.
- **Passive Resistance Association:** Gandhi established the Passive Resistance Association to carry out a campaign of opposing the law and experiencing the consequences of such defiance.
- **Compromised solution:** All of this cast a negative light on the South African administration. In the end, a compromise solution was reached.
- **Break the law:** The previous campaign was expanded to include opposition to new regulations restricting Indian migration. The Indians broke the law by crossing from one province to the next and refusing to provide licences.
- **Campaign Against Poll Tax and Invalidation of Indian Marriages:** A poll tax of three pounds was imposed on all ex-indentured Indians. The demand for the abolition of the poll tax broadened the campaign's base.
- **Invalidation of marriages:** Then there was the Supreme Court judgement that invalidated any marriages that were not done according to Christian customs and registered by the registrar of marriages.

Gandhi's Satyagraha Technique

- **Truth & nonviolence:** During his time in South Africa, Gandhi developed the Satyagraha technique. It was founded on truth and non-violence.

- **Confluence of many ideologies:** He merged parts of Indian culture with the Christian imperative of turning the other cheek and Tolstoy's ideology, which stated that nonviolent resistance was the greatest way to combat evil.
- **Willing to suffer:** A satyagrahi must be willing to suffer in his fight against the wrongdoer. This suffering was to be a part of his devotion to the truth.
- **Hatred is alien:** Even when fighting the wrongdoer, a true satyagrahi would have no ill will towards the wrongdoer; hatred would be alien to his character.
- **Only for the courageous and strong:** Satyagraha was only for the courageous and strong; it was not for the weak and cowardly. Violence was favoured over cowardice.

Gandhi's Initial Satyagraha after Arriving in India

1. The Champaran Satyagraha of 1917

- **Background and Indigo Exploitation**: British compelled peasants to grow indigo under the oppressive Tinkathia system—3/20th of land had to be used for indigo, with only one-third of the produce retained by farmers. Laws like the Bengal Tenancy Act worsened the exploitation, sometimes raising the quota to 5/20th.
- **Gandhi's Involvement**: Raj Kumar Shukla, a local indigo cultivator, invited Gandhi to Champaran in 1917. Witnessing the peasants' plight, Gandhi launched a satyagraha against the unjust plantation system.
- **Constructive Work and Mobilisation**: Alongside the agitation, Gandhi initiated village sanitation, opened schools and hospitals, and promoted social reforms like ending purdah and untouchability.
- **Impact and Legacy**: The movement forced British Authority to form Champaran agrarian Committee preside by F.G. Slay and ultimetly compromise with planters to only 25% of money compensated to framers. It marked Gandhi's emergence as a **mass leader**, earning him the titles **Bapu** and **Mahatma**.

2. Mills Strike in Ahmedabad, 1918

- **Workers' Demands and Gandhi's Role**: In 1918, Gandhi led a satyagraha in Ahmedabad to support cotton mill workers demanding the continuation of the 'Plague Bonus' even after the epidemic ended.
- **Strike and Fasting**: Gandhi intervened in the wage dispute between workers and mill owners, recommending a 35% wage hike (revised from workers' original 50%). When negotiations failed, he undertook a fast unto death, leading mill owners to concede.
- **Leadership Support**: Anasuya Behn, sister of mill owner Ambalal Sarabhai and a close ally of Gandhi, played a crucial role during the agitation.
- **Institutional Legacy**: Gandhi founded the *Ahmedabad Textile Labour Association*, laying the foundation for industrial relations in the city and giving him an urban, labour-oriented base.

3. Kheda or Kaira Satyagraha, 1918

- **Peasants' Crisis**: Gandhi launched a satyagraha in Kheda, Gujarat, to support peasants facing severe crop failure and plague, who were unable to pay increased land revenue.
- **Leadership and Mobilisation**: Sardar Vallabhbhai Patel and other Gandhians toured villages, mobilising peasants and offering political direction.
- **Regional Focus**: Although many from Ahmedabad and Vadodara wanted to join, Gandhi and Patel restricted the movement to Gujaratis to maintain its local character.
- **Outcome**: The British, facing strong resistance, agreed to waive land revenue for the current and following year.

Gains from Champaran, Ahmedabad, and Kheda

- **Satyagraha technique**: Gandhi demonstrated to the people the usefulness of his satyagraha technique.
- **Feet among the masses**: He found his feet among the masses and started to have a popular following.
- **Strengths and weaknesses**: He found his footing among the masses and gained a better knowledge of their strengths and weaknesses;
- **Respect and dedication**: He gained the respect and dedication of many, particularly the youth.

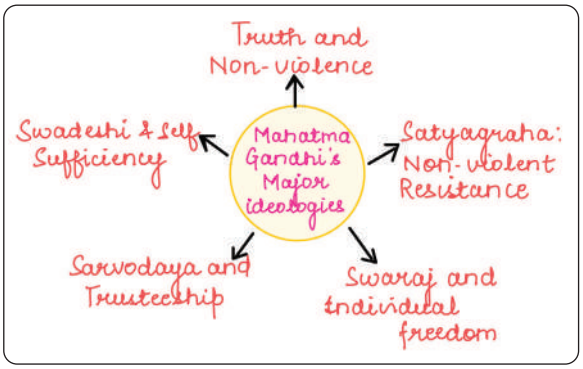

Fig. 8.2: Mahatma Gandhi's Major Ideologies
Diagram Type: *Hub & Spoke*

Gandhi's Major Ideologies

Relevance of Gandhian thoughts in Present Context (UPSC 2018)

- **Ethical Governance and Civil Services:** Truth was central to Gandhian thought, upheld by him in all circumstances. In today's era of widespread corruption, truthfulness and integrity are vital for civil servants. Gandhiji's emphasis on non-violence as a tool for resistance is equally relevant in conflict resolution and ethical public life. His principles support a transparent and accountable governance system, free from corruption.

- **Social Harmony and Tolerance:** Gandhiji promoted religious tolerance and secularism, essential in today's world plagued by communal and ethnic strife. His idea of tolerance can help reduce biases based on religion, caste, and ethnicity. He opposed caste discrimination and called the oppressed "Harijans", advocating for a casteless and inclusive society.
- **Inclusive Development and Decentralisation:** Gandhian socialism focused on eliminating poverty, hunger, and unemployment through universal access to education and healthcare. His ideas guide initiatives like Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan, Ayushman Bharat, and Skill India. He also advocated for decentralisation of power, now seen in the Panchayati Raj and municipal systems, empowering grassroots democracy.
- **Cleanliness and Inner Reform:** Gandhiji believed in "Swacchta Hi Seva", valuing both physical and internal cleanliness. The Swachh Bharat Mission echoes this thought, but Gandhiji also stressed moral purity, transparency, and ethical conduct for a truly clean and honest society.

Gandhi's idea that "Earth has enough for human needs, not for human greed" reinforces sustainable development. At a time of moral decline, Gandhian principles hold ethical and behavioural relevance, urging individuals to live responsibly for a peaceful and sustainable future.

Impact on Freedom Struggle after Gandhi's Arrival (UPSC 2014)

The entry of Mahatma Gandhi in the national freedom struggle dates back to 1915 when he returned from South Africa after two decades of socio/political struggle. Gandhi's style of politics, as developed through his political experiments in South Africa, changed the character of the national movement for freedom in India, which, until his arrival, was representing the classes:

- **Limitations Before Gandhi's Arrival:** The freedom movement before 1915 was confined to elite groups, with a narrow social-political base dominated by western-educated middle-class leaders. It reflected concentrated class interests, such as the Zamindari Association protecting landlord rights. Demands were limited and class-biased (e.g., Indianization of services, legislative representation). Organizational coherence was weak—moderate methods (prayer, petition, protest) failed, while extremist efforts lacked direction (e.g., Surat Split, limited Ghadar outcomes). Home Rule Leagues also faded due to internal divisions, communal strife, and ineffective mobilization.
- **Gandhi's Transformative Impact:** Gandhi's return in 1915 introduced mass-oriented politics, replacing elite-centric activism. Movements like *Champaran* and *Kheda Satyagraha* involved peasants and addressed grassroots issues. His approach brought subaltern groups into the mainstream—e.g., Harijan upliftment, women's participation in Non-Cooperation and Civil Disobedience movements.
- **Ethical and Inclusive Politics:** Gandhi prioritized means over ends, infusing idealism and ethics into the struggle. *Chauri Chaura* incident led to withdrawal of the Non-Cooperation Movement to uphold non-violence. His ideas of *Satyagraha* and *Ahimsa* shifted the struggle towards peaceful resistance. *Swaraj* evolved into a concept of self-reliance—promoting Khadi, village industries, and grassroots democracy.

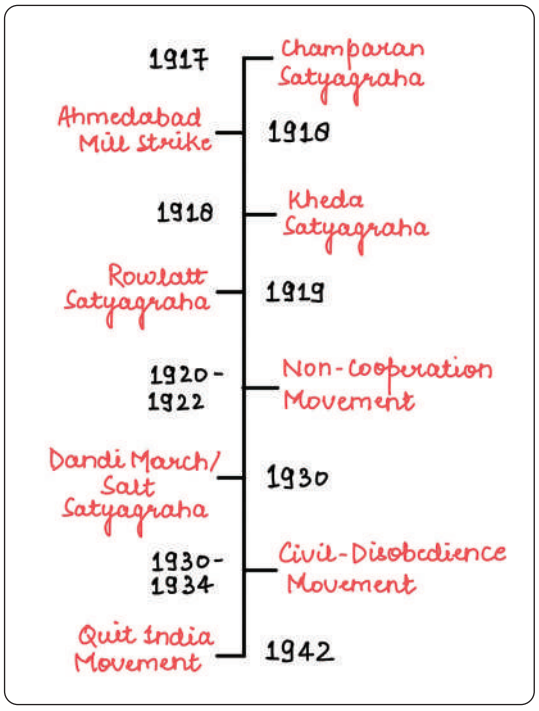

Fig. 8.3: Major Movement for Independence during Gandhian Era
Diagram Type: *Timeline*

- **Nation-Building Vision:** Gandhian politics laid the foundation for post-independence nation-building. His efforts for *Hindu-Muslim unity*, fight against *untouchability*, and push for communal harmony had long-term impacts. His moral leadership helped people overcome the fear instilled by colonial rule.
- **Strategic Resilience:** To sustain momentum, Gandhi introduced the *struggle–truce–struggle* approach. For instance, he resumed the Civil Disobedience Movement after the failure of the 2nd Round Table Conference, keeping the national spirit alive.

The Gandhian influence in the national freedom struggle is instrumental in shaping the values, ideas, and, interest of contemporary India. The same is reflected in our vision of Vasudev kutumbkam, liberal democracy, welfare of masses etc.

The Khilafat and Non-Cooperation Movement (1919 to 1922)

The **Lucknow Pact of 1916** laid the groundwork for Hindu Muslim unity in national struggle. The Turkey issue presented an opportunity for Gandhi to further establish unity links among Hindus and Muslims in preparation for a combined effort against the British.

Origin of Concept of Non-Cooperation

- **British rule because of cooperation of indians:** Mahatma Gandhi said in his renowned book Hind Swaraj (1909) that British rule in India was founded with the participation of Indians and had persisted only because of their cooperation.
- **Without indians comply british will end:** If Indians failed to comply, British control in India would end in a year, and Swaraj would take its place.
- **Success of the Rowlatt Satyagraha:** With the success of the Rowlatt Satyagraha under him, Gandhiji decided to take things to the next level, from Satyagrah to Non-Cooperation.

Co-operation vs. Non-Cooperation

- **Events which drove to non-cooperation:** While Gandhi was initially cooperative with the British, events in Punjab **(Jallianwala Bagh, Martial Law, Hunter report)** and Turkey's treatment of Khalifa drove him to embrace the non- cooperation route.
- **Indians stop cooperating, the rule will crumble**: Furthermore, as previously said, it was only Indian cooperation that kept British control in India going, and if Indians stop cooperating, the rule will **crumble.**

Background of Movement

- **Launch and Congress Endorsement:** The Non-Cooperation-Khilafat Movement began on August 1, 1920. In September, the Calcutta Congress led by Lala Lajpat Rai approved Gandhiji's plan to boycott the British government until justice was delivered for the Jallianwala Bagh massacre and the Khilafat issue, and Swaraj was achieved. It was ratified at the Nagpur Session in December 1920.
- **Mass Participation and Swaraj's Appeal:** Diverse socio-economic groups joined, each driven by unique concerns but united under the idea of Swaraj, which meant different things to different people. Prominent leaders like Motilal Nehru, Lala Lajpat Rai, Baba Ram Chandra, Pattabhai Sitaramaiya, and others mobilized regional support across India.
- **Educational and Institutional Boycott:** Thousands of students left British institutions, leading to the rise of national schools like Jamia Millia, Kashi Vidyapith, and Bihar Vidyapith. Leaders such as Subhash Chandra Bose and Zakir Hussain played key roles in these institutions. Teachers, headmasters, and lawyers also withdrew from colonial institutions.
- **Wider Political Impact:** The movement boycotted the 1920 council elections except in Madras, where the Justice Party participated. The Tilak-Swaraj Fund was launched to honour Tilak and exceeded Rs 1 crore. Jinnah and Malviya opposed the idea of Swaraj; Jinnah eventually left Congress after 15 years.
- **Challenge to British Rule:** For the first time since 1857, the movement posed a serious challenge to British authority. Gandhi asserted that Swaraj could be achieved within a year if the movement continued unwaveringly.

Significance of Non-Cooperation Movement

- **Economic consequences:** The economic consequences of non-cooperation were more dramatic. Foreign goods were boycotted, liquor stores were picketed, and foreign clothing was burned in massive bonfires.
- **Stifled in urban areas:** However, the movement was stifled in urban areas for a variety of reasons, including the fact that Khadi was more expensive than mass-produced mill cloth, and the urban poor couldn't afford it. There were difficulties in a complete boycott of British institutions because they provided vital services.
- **Non-Cooperation in Rural Areas**: The movement moved from cities to rural areas, including peasant and tribal areas.

Congress's Concerns about Non-Cooperation

- **Hesitant to boycott:** Many members of Congress, however, were apprehensive about the suggestions. They were hesitant to boycott the November 1920 council elections because they thought the initiative would spark public unrest.
- **Heated debate:** Between september, 1920 and December, 1920, there was a heated debate within the Congress. For a time, it appeared like there was no point of convergence between the movement's supporters and opponents.
- **Led by Gandhi:** Mahatma Gandhi led the non-cooperation campaign (1920-22). Veteran Leaders such as Bal Gangadhar Tilak, Bipin Chandra Pal, Mohammad Ali Jinnah, and Annie Besant were vehemently opposed to the proposal. However, the younger generation of Indian nationalists cheered and supported Gandhiji.
- **Widespread support:** His initiatives were embraced by the Congress Party, and he had widespread support from Muslim leaders such as Abul Kalam Azad, Mukhtar Ahmed Ansari, Hakim Ajmal Khan, Abbas Tyabji, Maulana Mohammad Ali, and Maulana Shaukat Ali.

Reasons for Gandhi Withdrew from the Movement

- **Chauri-Chaura incidents (4 February, 1922):** Gandhi believed that people had not fully learned or grasped the nonviolent way. Incidents like Chauri-Chaura might spark the kind of passion and energy that would render the movement violent in general.
- **Violent movement:** A violent movement could be readily suppressed by the colonial authority, which could exploit the incidences of violence as a reason to utilise the State's armed force against the protestors.

- **Signs of wear and tear:** The movement was also showing signs of wear and tear. This was natural because it is impossible to sustain any movement at a high pitch for an extended period of time.
- **Not interested in negotiations:** The government appeared to be not interested in negotiations.
- **Khilafat issue faded:** The agitation's core focus, the Khilafat issue, likewise faded quickly. Turkey's people rose up in November 1922, led by Mustafa Kamal Pasha, and deposed the Sultan of political power. Turkey has been declared a secular state. As a result, the Khilafat issue became irrelevant.
- **Rewrote 'The Treaty of Severs':** The British rewrote 'The Treaty of Severs' in favour of Turkey. The cause of unity vanished, and Muslims were no longer associated with Congress.
- **Ali brothers' and Muslims' support:** The Ali brothers' and Muslims' support was religious rather than nationalistic. As their support for the cause dwindled, so did theirs.
- **Moplah incident:** The Moplah incident caused tremendous hostility between Hindus and Muslims.

Achievements	Shortcomings
❖ **Congress became a popular party:** Previously, one of the most serious criticisms levelled against Congress was that it was a party of elites representing just a fraction of the population. ❖ **Participation of all sections**: For the first time, participants came from all sections. From the 1920 Congress Session, the joining cost was significantly cut, as was the age of joining, taking it into even villages and expanding its mass base. ❖ **Powerful leaders emerged**: The Khilafat movement produced several powerful leaders, including Maulana Azad, Saifuddin Kitchlew, M A Ansari, and others. ❖ **Charkha as a National Symbol**: Gandhi provided fresh intellectual backing in the shape of nonviolence and satyagraha, which later became crucial tools for national resistance. ❖ **Muslims also participated**: With the exception of the Moplah insurrection in Malabar, the movement saw Muslim participation. ❖ **Remove British fear**: Removed people's fear of British might from their thoughts. **Educational institutes formed**: Many educational institutes were formed, including Jamia Millia Islamia, Bihar Vidyapeeth, Kashi Vidyapith, Gujarat Vidyapith, and others.	❖ **Swaraj not accomplished:** Swaraj, as declared, was not accomplished in a year. Many people were disappointed by this. ❖ **Muslim Alienation**: Failure of Non-Cooperation also means failure of Khilafat. The Ali brothers blamed Congress for their failure. Further congressional actions drew less enthusiastic cooperation from Muslims. ❖ **Divide in Congress:** With the recall of the movement, many disliked it, while others grew eager to participate in provincial elections, giving birth to the Swaraj Party. ❖ **Revival of Revolutionary activity:** This also gave birth to the second phase of revolutionary activity following Bengal's division. ❖ **Mass Reach:** Khadi was unaffordable to the poor, which drove the middle and lower classes away from the movement.

Swaraj Party (1923)

Reasons for Formation of Swaraj Party

- **Split Over Gandhi's Withdrawal:** Gandhiji's sudden suspension of the Non-Cooperation Movement angered leaders like C.R. Das, Motilal Nehru, N.C. Kelkar, and others, leading to the formation of the Swaraj Party on January 1, 1923, as a response to his decision.
- **Council Entry Debate:** The party aimed to contest elections to legislative councils (Montford Reforms, 1919) to obstruct British rule from within. This led to a rift between *Pro-Changers* (C.R. Das, Motilal Nehru, Hakim Ajmal Khan) and *No-Changers* (Rajendra Prasad, Vallabhbhai Patel, C. Rajagopalachari), who opposed council entry, fearing it would dilute mass work and co-opt leaders.
- **Gaya Session and Formation:** At the 1922 Gaya Session, the Pro-Changers' proposal was rejected. In response, they launched the Swaraj Party while still staying within the Congress fold, which was later formally accepted in the 1923 Delhi meet.
- **Changing Gandhi's Stance:** Initially opposed, Gandhi later supported the Swarajists' efforts after his release, especially their constructive work, and endorsed them during the 1924 Belgaum Session.
- **Electoral Politics and Decline:** The Swaraj Party contested the 1923-24 elections, won major seats, formed coalitions, and raised nationalist demands in councils. After C.R. Das's death (1925), many leaders withdrew. A faction continued as the *Responsivist Party* (Lajpat Rai, Malviya, Jayakar), cooperating with the British. The party's influence declined by the 1926 elections due to internal issues and rival campaigns.

Assessment of Swaraj Party

Success	Swarajist Shortcomings
❖ **Defeating the Public Safety Bill**: Nonetheless, it managed to pull off some good jobs, such as defeating the Public Safety Bill of 1928, which attempted to deport subversive elements inspired by communist ideology. ❖ **Filled the political void**: They filled the political void left by Gandhiji's absence from the political scene when the national movement was at its weakest. ❖ **Exposed the hollowness**: They exposed the hollowness of the 1919 Act. ❖ **Political awareness**: The active engagement of Motilal and CR Das in the assembly drew the attention of the media, which served to pique people's interest in the workings of Legislative assemblies and raised their political awareness level. ❖ **Revealed the true nature of regional governments**: It revealed the true nature of regional governments as well as the hollowness of the 1919 reforms. ❖ **Intensive budget study**: It also effectively revealed the budget, and for the first time, an intensive budget study was performed.	❖ **Unable to make a dent in government policies:** They were unable to make a dent in government policies and were soon drawn into power politics. ❖ **Unable to connect:** They were unable to connect with the general public. ❖ **Alienated Muslim supporters:** They alienated Muslim supporters of rural interests. ❖ **Suffering of Bengal's peasants:** They were likewise powerless to alleviate the suffering of Bengal's peasants.

The Simon Commission (1928)

- **Introduction**: Created in reaction to the nationalist movement, the commission was tasked with investigating the functioning of the constitutional system facilitated by the 1919 Act in India and making recommendations for modifications. The Simon Commission was established by Britain Prime Minister Stanley Baldwin on November 8, 1927 and published report in May, 1930.
- **Committee to review the progress of the governance model:** The Indian population demanded that the burdensome diarchy system of government be revised, and the Government of India Act 1919 itself stated that a committee would be constituted after ten years to review the progress of the governance model.
- **Not a single Indian member:** The Indian people were enraged and insulted because the Simon Commission, which was to determine India's future, did not include a single Indian member.

Proposals of Simon Commission

- **Outline of a new constitution**: An outline of a new constitution was proposed.
- **Diarchy should be abolished**: Diarchy should be abolished, and Ministers accountable to the Legislature should be entrusted with all provincial responsibilities. It was staunchly opposed to diarchy in the centre. Instead of a diarchy, it advocated for a responsible provincial government.
- **Proposed a fully federal union**: It proposed that a fully federal union, embracing both British India and the Princely States, was the only long-term answer for a united, autonomous India.
- **Franchise be expanded**: It proposed that the franchise be expanded and the Legislature is expanded.
  - North west frontier provinces and Baluchistan should get local legislatures and rights to be represented at the center.
  - Sindh to be separated from Bombay and Burma to be separated from India.
  - Indian army should be Indianised.
  - Consultative council of greater India to be established.

Response of Nationalists and Congress

- **Congress opposed:** Congress agreed to oppose it in Madras in 1927. The main reason for its criticism was that, despite the Commission's goal of assessing constitutional improvements in India, all of its members were white, with no Indian representation.
- **Go back, Simon:** When the Simon Commission arrived in India in 1928, it was met by black flags and the chant "Go back, Simon."

Emergence of a New Generation of Youth

- **Opportunity for youth to demonstrate their worth:** The Simon Commission provided an opportunity for youth to demonstrate their worth. This Commission, as well as the death of Lala Lajpat Rai, fuelled the spirit of Bhagat Singh and others.
- **Emergence of new socialist ideologies:** Following the commission, a new generation of youthful leaders emerged to prominence, including Bhagat Singh and Subhash. This influx of youth saw the emergence of new socialist ideologies.

Impact of the Appointment of Simon Commission on the National Movement

- **Massive socio economic reforms along socialist lines:** It provided a boost to radical elements demanding not only complete independence but also massive socio economic reforms along socialist lines.
- **Organise mass action:** When the Simon Commission was announced, the Congress, which had no active plan, was given an issue on which to organise mass action.
- **Prospects for Indian unity:** Lord Birkenhead's challenge to Indian politicians to produce an agreed constitution was embraced by many political groupings, and therefore prospects for Indian unity appeared bright at the moment.

The Nehru Report (1928)

The 'Nehru Report' (1928) was a paper proposing a proposed new Dominion constitution (not a constitution in and of itself) for India. It was drafted by an All Parties Conference committee chaired by Motilal Nehru, with his son Jawaharlal serving as secretary. This committee had nine other members, including two Muslims. While the report did not advocate for complete independence, the constitution proposed in the Nehru report called for India to have dominion status within the British Commonwealth. The majority of its proposals became the foundation of independent India's constitution.

Recommendations	
1. It requested Dominion Status.	2. It had a Bill of Rights, unlike the eventual Government of India Act 1935.
3. It made no provision for Seprate electorates or weightage for minorities.	4. It pushed for a federal framework.
5. Separation of the state and religion.	6. A parliamentary system of government.
7. Residual authority with the federal/central government	8. Adult franchise.
9. Linguistic redistribution of province boundaries.	

Why Report Was Opposed?

- **Abolished the Communal/Separate Electorate:** It abolished the Communal/Separate Electorate, which enraged the Muslim League and other minority populations.
- **Dominion Status:** It requested Dominion Status rather than complete Independence - on this point, even Jawahar Lal disagreed with his father (as seen by his desire for Purna Swaraj a year later). The 'Independence for India League' was founded by Nehru and Subhash.
- **Sectarian clash:** The report was not accepted by the Muslim League, Hindu Mahasabha, or fervent Sikhs, and it prepared the scenario for a sectarian clash.

Jinnah's 14 Point

- In response, Mohammad Ali Jinnah formulated his Fourteen Points in 1929, which became the main demands of the Muslim community for participation in an independent united India.
- **Main points of 14-Point Formula:**
  - Separate electoral districts
  - 33% of seats in central legislatures are reserved for Muslims.
  - Provinces have residual powers.
  - Regional autonomy
  - No constitutional alteration by the centre without the approval of the states that comprise the federation.
  - Adequate Muslim representation in services

Demand of Purna Swaraj (1929)

- **Background:** After the Nehru Report, which defied their expectations by stating Dominion Status as their demand, Jawaharlal Nehru, Subhas Chandra Bose, and Satyamurti became more assertive.
- **Hesitancy:** However, Motilal Nehru and Gandhi were hesitant to give up the achievements they had won by claiming Dominion Status, and they urged that the government grant them a year's time.
- **Liberals stance:** This, however, did not ease the feelings of liberals or Jawahar Lal and others.
- **Purna swaraj:** In December 1929, the Lahore Congress, presided over by Jawaharlal Nehru, formalised the demand for 'Purna Swaraj,' or full independence for India.

  Indian flag: On December 31, Jawahar unfurled the Indian flag at the Ravi Bank at midnight.

Following Major Choices Were Made

- **Boycott**: Boycott of the Round Table Conference.
- **Poorna Swaraj**: Push for Poorna Swaraj.
- **Right to resign**: All members of the legislature have the right to resign.
- **Freedom Day:** It was proclaimed that January 26, 1930, would be celebrated as Freedom Day, with individuals taking a commitment to fight for complete freedom.
- **Generational shift in leadership**: The Lahore session also saw a generational shift in leadership.
- **Gandhi's leadership**: It was also determined that a civil disobedience movement would be launched under Gandhi's leadership.
- **Commitments made for Purna Swaraj**: A nationwide meeting was called, and there was a large turnout from both rural and urban areas, with commitments made for Purna Swaraj.

Civil Disobedience Movement of 1930

Following the government's inaction on the Nehru Report and its failure to agree on any demand for even dominion status, Gandhiji sought a fresh strategy amid mounting discontent among the Congress and the nation as a whole. Gandhi took the decision to start the Civil Disobedience movement. On 12 March, 1930 Gandhi alongwith his band of 78 Members, started the Historic Salt March from his Sabarmati Ashram and reach. Dandi coast on April 6, 1930.

Demands of Mahatma Gandhi

- **Demand for Purna Swaraj:** On January 31, 1930, shortly after the demand for Purna Swaraj was made, he submitted a letter to Viceroy Irwin outlining eleven demands (11 points).
- **Broaden objective:** The objective was to broaden the demands so that all classes within Indian society could connect with them and join forces in a single campaign.
- **Prominent Demands:** These included, among other things, total prohibition, the release of political prisoners, the levy of duty on foreign cloth, the issuance of firearm licences, the reduction of land revenue by 50%, the reduction of the Rupee Sterling exchange ratio to make Indian exports profitable, the reserve of coastal shipping for Indians, and the abolition of the salt tax.
- **Most stirring demand:** The most stirring demand was to repeal the salt charge. Salt was something that was consumed by both the rich and the poor, and it was one of the most important food items.
- **Exposed the most repressive face of British authority:** Mahatma Gandhi exposed the most repressive face of British authority by taxing salt and granting the government a monopoly on its production.

Indian Response to the Proposed 11 Points

- **Initial Reaction and Industrial Support:** Nationalists were displeased with the 11 Points, seeing them as conflicting with the recent Swaraj Declaration. The industrial class supported Gandhi's demands as they aligned with their economic interests.
- **British Apathy and Salt March:** Gandhi warned of launching Civil Disobedience if demands weren't met by 11 March. With no response from Irwin, Gandhi began the *Salt March* with 78 followers, including Sarojini Naidu. Congress empowered him to lead the movement.
- **Mass Participation and Salt Law Violation:** The march drew massive public attention. Gandhi spread the idea of *swaraj* and urged peaceful defiance. Salt laws were broken across India—C. Rajagopalachari led the Tamil Nadu march, K. Kelappan in Malabar, and women like Kamla Nehru and Swarup Rani played leading roles.
- **Nationwide Civil Disobedience:** People across the country made salt, defied bans, and picketed government salt depots. Foreign cloth was boycotted, liquor shops picketed, peasants stopped paying revenue, village officials resigned, and forest laws were openly violated.
- **Regional Uprisings and Leaders:** The *Chowkidar Tax* was resisted in eastern India. In the south and central regions, forest rules were flouted. *Khan Abdul Ghaffar Khan* led the *Khudai Khidmatgar* in the NWFP. In Manipur, *Rani Gaidinliu*, aged 13, joined the movement and was jailed for life.
- **No-Tax and Public Mobilisation Campaigns:** The *Bardoli Satyagraha* (1928), led by Patel, became a model for later no-tax movements. In UP, the 'No-Revenue, No-Rent' campaign targeted both zamindars and cultivators. Mass mobilisation tools like *Prabhat Pheris, Patrikas, Vanar Sena* (children), and *Manjari Sena* (girls) were effectively used.

Reaction of the Britishers

- **Arrest of Congress leaders:** Concerned about the situation, the colonial authorities began arresting Congress leaders one by one.
- **Violent fights:** This resulted in violent fights in a number of palaces.

- **Ruthless repression policy:** A terrified government responded with a ruthless repression policy. Satyagrahis who were peaceful were attacked, women and children were beaten, and around 60,000 people were jailed.
- **Detention of Prominent politicians:** C Rajagopalachari, Vallabhai, Jawahar, Madan Mohan Malviya, J M Sengupta, and other prominent politicians were also detained. In May 1930, Gandhi was captured as well, and leadership was handed to Abbas Tyabji, who was also arrested. Sarojini eventually seized the lead, but she was also jailed.
- **Congress was proclaimed unconstitutional:** The government issued numerous repressive resolutions,' and Congress was proclaimed unconstitutional.

Assessment of Movement

Positives	Failures
❖ **Historic salt march**: Mahatma Gandhi began his historic salt march with 78 of his loyal volunteers, including Sarojini Naidu. The Congress gave Gandhi the authority to initiate the Civil Disobedience Movement. ❖ **Mass participation**: Thousands swarmed to hear Mahatma Gandhi wherever he went, and he explained what he meant by swaraj and exhorted them to defy the British peacefully. ❖ **Broaden objective**: The objective was to broaden the demands so that all classes within Indian society could connect with them and join forces in a single campaign. ❖ **Support of Industrial class**: The industrial class wholeheartedly supported Gandhian demands in full since they considered them as more of an economic nature.	❖ **Not move all social groupings:** The abstract concept of swaraj did not move all social groupings. ❖ **Untouchables:** One such group was the nation's 'untouchables,' who began calling themselves Dalit or oppressed in the 1930s. ❖ **Muslims are apathetic:** Except for the NWFP under Khan Abdul Gaffar Khan, Muslims are apathetic. They were polarised by leaders' communal rhetoric as well as the government's favourable response to their demands. ❖ **Lukewarm support:** The Industrial Class is only providing lukewarm support. ❖ **Poor participants:** Peasants were poor participants.

Non-Cooperation Vs. Civil Disobedience

- **Contravene colonial laws:** Instead of simply refusing to cooperate with the British, as they had done in 1921-22, people were now asked to contravene colonial laws. As a result, there was an ideological evolution.
- **Ultimate freedom:** The goal this time was ultimate freedom.
- **Gandhi into the international stage:** Although Muslim involvement was low at the time, as was labour participation, this campaign launched Gandhi into the international stage, and for the first time, women joined in huge numbers in a national movement.
- **Countrywide participation:** In NCM, the movement was restricted to certain areas of the country whereas, in CDM Several Indian leaders actively participated in this movement.
- **Decline:** Non-cooperation movement faded once it grew violent following the Chauri Chaura incident, whereas, in CDM after Mahatma Gandhi signed a pact with Irwin, the campaign declined.

Other Aspects of Non-Cooperation Movement and the Civil Disobedience Movement in the Indian freedom struggle:

Aspect	Non-Cooperation Movement	Civil Disobedience Movement
Time Period	1920-1922	1930-1934
Launched By	Mahatma Gandhi	Mahatma Gandhi
Key Features	Boycott of foreign goods, educational institutions, government services, and courts.	Refusal to obey certain laws, demands, and commands of the government. Includes the Salt March as a key event.
Immediate Cause	Jallianwala Bagh Massacre and the Rowlatt Act	Failure of Simon Commission and the resultant discontent
Methods	Non-violent resistance through non-cooperation	Non-violent resistance, but with a direct violation of specific laws (e.g., making salt)
Objective	To attain Swaraj (self-rule) as defined by the Congress	To challenge the legality and authority of British laws and to demand Purna Swaraj (complete independence)

Government Response	Suppression through arrests, violence, and concessions like the end of the Rowlatt Act	Severe crackdown, mass arrests, negotiations at the Second Round Table Conference
Outcome/ Impact	Strengthened nationalism, showed the power of mass movements, led to Gandhi's arrest	Enhanced political activism, significant international attention, eventual negotiations for greater self-rule

Why was Salt Selected as the Important Theme?

- **Most inhuman poll tax:** As Gandhi put it, "There is no other article, outside of water, by taxing which the government can reach the starving millions, the sick, the maimed, and the completely helpless... it is the most inhuman poll tax."
- **Instantly linked the ideal of swaraj:** Salt, like khadi, instantly linked the ideal of swaraj with a most palpable and universal grievance of the rural poor.
- **Symbolic association with mass suffering:** It afforded the urban public the chance of symbolic association with mass suffering.

Gandhi – Irwin Pact or Delhi Pact (March 1931) and its Significance

- As British repression got more severe during the Civil Disobedience Movement, ordinary people suffered.
- In such circumstances, Mahatma Gandhi chose to call off the agitation once more, and he, along with many others, was arrested.
- Congress did not attend the inaugural Round Table Conference, which was attended by the Muslim League, Hindu Mahasabha, Chamber of Princes, Liberals, and Dalits, and it was thought that any accord reached without Congress' participation would be meaningless.
- Irwin was also eager to find a solution, and in a symbolic gesture, he released the political prisoners and decided to speak directly to Gandhi. In this context, Gandhi made an agreement with Irwin on March 5, 1931.
- The Pact brought Congress on equal footing with the government, and Irwin's move was criticised in Britain for taking up too much room.

Proposed Conditions

- **Salt Concession:** People living within a specified distance of the seashore were allowed to manufacture or collect salt without paying any tax or duty.
- **Release of Political Prisoners:** All political prisoners not involved in violent activities were to be released immediately.
- **Fines and Land Returns:** All fines imposed but not yet collected were to be remitted, and confiscated land not sold to third parties was to be returned.
- **Withdrawal of Repressive Measures:** All ordinances and pending prosecutions against Congress workers were to be withdrawn.
- **Leniency Towards Resigned Officials:** Government employees who had resigned as part of the movement were to be treated leniently.
- **Peaceful Protest Rights:** Non-aggressive and peaceful picketing of liquor and foreign cloth shops was allowed.
- **In exchange, Gandhi and the Congress agreed to:**
  - **Suspend the Civil Disobedience Movement:** The ongoing mass protest and defiance of colonial laws were to be halted.
  - **Participation in Second RTC:** Congress would send representatives, including Gandhi, to the Second Round Table Conference in London.

Things that the British Refused to Accept as Part of the Gandhi-Irwin Pact or the Delhi Pact

- **Police investigation:** The Congress' request for a police investigation into arrests and atrocities committed during the Civil Disobedience movement was denied.
- **Not accept the commutation:** We will not accept the commutation of Bhagat Singh's and his companions' sentences.
- **Refused to accept the extremist demand:** The accord also refused to accept the radicals' demand for the rapid restoration of lands confiscated during the campaign.

The Pact's Outcome

- **Attend in a Round Table Conference:** Gandhiji agreed to attend a Round Table Conference in London as part of the Gandhi-Irwin Pact, and the government committed to release political prisoners.
- **Criticised by extremists:** The alliance was criticised by radicals for failing to garner clear gains from the government and for surrendering on Swaraj's demand by agreeing to participate in the Round Table Conference.

Advantage of the occasion: Gandhiji may have been aware that huge movements are fundamentally fleeting, and he attempted to take advantage of the occasion by extracting some gains from the British administration.

Was the Gandhi-Irwin Pact a Reversal?

- **Not a retreat**: Gandhi's decision to halt civil disobedience as agreed in the Gandhi-Irwin Pact was not a retreat,
- **Limited capacity of masses to sacrifice:** The capacity of the masses to make sacrifices, unlike that of activists, is limited; and There were symptoms of tiredness after September 1930, particularly among shopkeepers and merchants who had engaged so energetically.

Karachi Session (March 1931)

- **Goal was to approve the Gandhi-Irwin Pact:** The Gandhi-Irwin pact was criticised by radical nationalists because it was unable to obtain from the Viceroy a commitment to political independence for Indians; it had not even agreed to the demand that Bhagat Singh's and his two comrades' death sentences be commuted to life imprisonment. It was dubbed a bourgeoise pact since it overlooked the people. However, the session's goal was to approve the Gandhi-Irwin Pact.
- **Meeting to endorse the agreement:** Gandhiji persuaded the meeting to endorse the agreement. Angered protestors greeted him with a black flag and flowers. Furthermore, Gandhiji and Congress were challenged as national representatives in that congress by three groups: the Muslim League, the Princely States, and BR Ambedkar (who accused Congress of disregarding the welfare of lower castes).

Significance of Session

- **Endorsed Gandhi-Irwin Pact:** It endorsed the Delhi Pact or the Gandhi-Irwin Pact.
- **Resolution on Fundamental Rights:** It moved a resolution on Fundamental Rights for the first time, and the draft resolution was written by Jawahar Lal Nehru (the session was presided over by Vallabhai Patel).
- **Underlined it as a goal of purna swaraj:** It explained the concept of Purna Swaraj for the first time and underlined it as a goal.
- **Interests of minorities will be protected:** It also stated that the interests of minorities will be protected, as well as their culture.
- **Recognised sacrifices:** It recognised Bhagat Singh's and others' valiant sacrifice.
- **Foundation of Congress's political and economic agendas:** The Karachi Resolution is significant because it became the foundation of Congress's political and economic agendas in succeeding years.

Second Round Table Conference, its Significances and Impacts

- **Boycott of first RTC:** The Congress boycotted the inaugural Round Table Conference (1930), which was attended by princely states, Ambedkar, and other non-Congress parties. Ambedkar also broached the notion of a separate electorate for Dalits, while Jinnah requested stronger safeguards for Muslims (both of these requests were represented in the 1932 Communal Award).
- **Gandhi-Irwin Pact:** Following the Gandhi-Irwin Pact, Gandhi was dispatched as a Congress delegate.

Concerning the Second Round Table Conference

- **Constitutional evolution envisioned:** The round table conference was in line with the constitutional evolution envisioned by the British, which was also articulated by the Simon Commission to lay out a future course of action for India's political system.
- **Essentially a single conference divided:** Though the round table conferences were labelled as first, second, and third. It would be incorrect to call it that because it was essentially a single conference divided over three sessions.
- **New Viceroy Willingdon:** Irwin was replaced by new Viceroy Willingdon in April, just before the Second Round Table Conference, and he was not ready to adopt Irwin's liberal stance.
- **Non-Congress parties:** The British also heavily involved non-Congress parties in the Second Round Table Conference.
- **Negotiations broke down:** Gandhiji travelled to London for the summit in December 1931, but negotiations broke down over the minority issue. Not only Muslims requested separate elections; this time, minorities led by Ambedkar demanded separate elections as well.

Outcomes

- **Formation of NWFP and Sindh:** The formation of two new Muslim-majority provinces, NWFP and Sindh.
- **Indian Consultative Committee:** Formation of an Indian Consultative Committee.
- **Communal Award(1932):** The possibility of a unilateral Communal Award.
- **Conservative government:** Churchill's new right/conservative government refused to place Congress on an equal footing and took a strong stance; as a result, the new Viceroy refused to meet with Gandhiji.
- **Congress was proclaimed illegal:** Gaffar Khan and Jawaharlal Nehru were both imprisoned, the Congress was proclaimed illegal, and a slew of restrictions were put in place to prevent gatherings, rallies, and boycotts.

- **Harsh stance against Gandhi:** The press was restrained, and Congress was still facing a ban. Former Viceroy Irwin had taken a harsh stance against Gandhi, and the new Viceroy Willingdon and Secretary of State decided not to engage any more.
- **Relaunched the Civil Disobedience Movement:** Mahatma Gandhi relaunched the Civil Disobedience Movement with profound trepidation. The movement lasted more than a year, but by 1934, it had lost steam owing to government harassment.

Reasons for the failure of the Second Phase of the Civil Disobedience Movement: Imprisonment of Major leaders, Poor Peasantry Support and a low inertia of Gandhian politics.

Revolutionary Activities

- **Nonviolent resistance could not be won:** Meanwhile, many nationalists believed that nonviolent resistance to the British could not be won.
- **Hindustan Socialist Republican Association:** The Hindustan Socialist Republican Association (HSRA) was created in 1928 as an offshoot of the Hindustan Republican Association visibly influenced by socialist principles at a conference in Ferozeshah Kotla field in Delhi.
- **HSRA targeted symbols of British power:** Bhagat Singh, Jatin Das, and Ajoy Ghosh were among its leaders. The HSRA targeted some of the symbols of British power in a series of dramatic activities across India.
- **Bomb in the Legislative Assembly:** Bhagat Singh and Batukeswar Dutta detonated a bomb in the Legislative Assembly in April 1929. An effort was made the same year to blow up the train that Lord Irwin was travelling in.

Communal Award (1932) and Poona Pact (1932)

Following the failure of Round Table Talks, the British government declared that if a consensus on the separate representation of minorities could not be established, a unilateral communal award would be made. The government kept its promise in the shape of the 1932 Communal Awardon the recommnedation of Franchise Commiitee(Lothian Committee).

Communal Prize and its Aftermath

- **Separate electorates:** On 16 August, 1932, British Prime Minister Ramsay McDonald issued the Communal Award to grant separate electorates to minority communities in India, including Muslims, Sikhs, and Dalit.
- **Special constituencies:** The depressed classes were allotted a number of seats to be filled by special constituencies in which only voters from the depressed classes could vote.
- **Award was opposed by Congress:** The award was opposed by Congress and other nationalist groups since it provided for a separate electorate and was seen as part of Britain's 'Divide and Rule' programme.
- **English Attack on Hindu-Muslim Unity:** Mahatma Gandhi was outraged by the award and strongly opposed it. Gandhi referred to the prize as an "English Attack on Hindu-Muslim Unity."

Concerns of Gandhi

- **Opposition to Separate Electorates:** Gandhi opposed separate electorates for Dalits, believing they needed an end to untouchability, not political separation. He feared it could lead to fragmentation, as seen in the Muslim case.
- **Hunger Strike and Poona Pact:** To protest the Communal Award, Gandhi began a hunger strike on September 20, 1932, at Yerwada Jail. With Madan Mohan Malviya mediating, Gandhi and Ambedkar reached the Poona Pact—creating a unified Hindu electorate with increased reserved seats for Dalits.
- **Minority Support for the Award:** Leaders like Dr B.R. Ambedkar initially supported the Communal Award. However, other religious groups like Muslims and Sikhs retained their separate electorates.
- **Post-Pact Dalit Upliftment:** After the Pact, Gandhi intensified efforts for Dalit welfare. He launched the magazine *Harijan* and dedicated a year to grassroots work against untouchability.
- **Hindu Opposition:** Despite his intentions, Gandhi's campaign faced strong resistance from orthodox Hindu sections.

Views of Ambedkar on Communal Award

- **Supportive**: *He backed the Communal Award.*
- **Views on Gandhi**: *Gandhi, according to Ambedkar, was willing to provide Muslims and Sikhs separate electorates. However, Gandhi was hesitant to offer scheduled castes distinct electorates.*

Impact of Poona Pact on Dalits

- **Failed to achieve the ultimate goal:** Despite providing significant political rights to the oppressed classes, the Poona Pact failed to achieve the ultimate goal of depressed class emancipation. It allowed the same old Hindu social structure to persist while also giving birth to a slew of issues.

- **Pact turned the poor into political tools:** The Pact turned the poor into political tools that could be employed by majoritarian caste Hindu outfits.
- **Rendered the oppressed classes leaderless:** It rendered the oppressed classes leaderless since authentic representatives of the classes were unable to defeat the stooges picked and sponsored by caste Hindu organisations.
- **Hindu social order:** By denying the impoverished classes a distinctive and distinct life, it subjected them to the Hindu social order.
- **Hampered the development of an ideal society:** The Poona Pact may have hampered the development of an ideal society founded on equality, liberty, fraternity, and justice.
- **Rights and freedoms of the Dalits:** It pre-empted the rights and freedoms of the Dalits by refusing to identify them as a separate and distinct element of national life and safeguards for the Dalits in the Constitution of independent India.

Gandhi's Harijan Campaign and Thoughts on Caste

Determined to undermine the destructive aims of the government's divide-and-rule programme, Gandhi abandoned all other interests and launched a frenzied campaign against untouchability—first from prison and then, after his release in August 1933, from outside jail.

Gandhi's Campaign Against Untouchability

- **Organisational Efforts and Nationwide Campaign:** While in jail (1932), Gandhi founded the *All India Anti-Untouchability League* and later launched the periodical *Harijan* (1933). After his release, he shifted to *Wardha's Satyagraha Ashram*, vowing not to return to Sabarmati till Swaraj was achieved. From 1933–34, he toured 20,000 km across India, raising funds for the *Harijan Sevak Sangh* and promoting the abolition of untouchability.
- **Advocacy and Social Message:** Gandhi urged activists to engage directly with oppressed communities and work for their upliftment—socially, economically, politically, and culturally. He conducted two fasts in 1934 (May 8 and Aug 16) to show commitment to the cause. He emphasized temple entry for Harijans and called on caste Hindus to perform 'penance' for past injustices.
- **Opposition and Challenges:** Traditionalists protested against Gandhi with black flags and accused him of being anti-Hindu. These groups opposed the Civil Disobedience Movement and helped defeat the *Temple Entry Bill* (Aug 1934). Despite opposition, Gandhi remained committed to peaceful reform.
- **Philosophy and Ideological Differences:** Gandhi's approach was rooted in humanist and rational principles. He argued Shastras do not justify untouchability and must be ignored if they do. He rejected linking the issue with *inter-caste marriage and dining*, believing such practices were socially restricted even within castes. He differed from *Ambedkar*, as Gandhi wanted untouchability removed without abolishing the caste system entirely, which he viewed differently from untouchability.

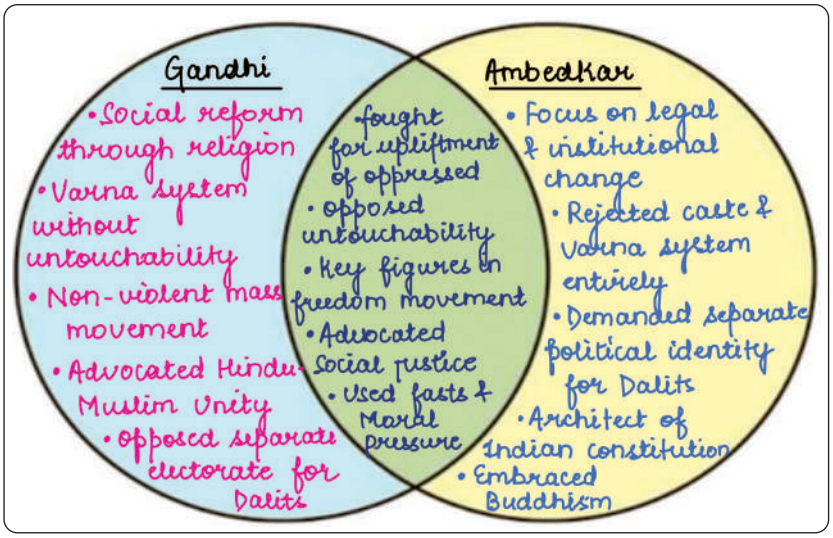

Fig. 8.4: Gandhi and Ambedkar (UPSC 2015)
Diagram Type: *Venn*

- **Internal Reform Agenda:** His *Harijan campaign* focused on internal upliftment through education, hygiene, sanitation, dietary reform (avoiding beef/carrion), and reducing discrimination within Harijan communities themselves.

Impact of Gandhi's Campaign

- **Not intended to be a political movement:** Gandhi consistently stated that the campaign was not intended to be a political movement, but rather to purify Hinduism and Hindu culture.
- **Spread the message of nationalism to Harijans:** The campaign gradually spread the message of nationalism to Harijans, who also happened to be agricultural labourers in most regions of the country, resulting in increased engagement in national and peasant activities.

The Government of India Act of 1935

The Act established an all-India federal framework consisting of principal states and provinces. The inclusion of the Princely States was conceived as a counterbalance to the provinces' burgeoning nationalism.

Salient Features of the Act

- **Federal Structure (Unrealised):** Introduced a federal system with a Federal, Provincial, and Concurrent List. However, princely states didn't join, so federalism remained on paper. A bicameral federal legislature was proposed, with state representatives nominated by rulers, not elected.
- **Provincial Autonomy:** Diarchy was abolished at the provincial level and replaced with provincial autonomy. Responsible government was introduced—governors had to act on ministers' advice. Bicameral legislatures were set up in 6 out of 11 provinces.
- **Diarchy at Centre & British Control:** Diarchy introduced at the federal level. Governors and the Governor-General retained overriding powers, including veto, control over civil services and police. Defence and foreign affairs remained under British control.
- **Electoral Reforms:** Separate electorates for Hindus and Muslims continued. Franchise was limited—only 14% of the population could vote. Budget voting was allowed, and concepts like 'Vote of No Confidence' and 'Collective Responsibility' were introduced.
- **Administrative Changes & Institutions:** Burma was separated from India. The Act led to the creation of the Federal Court, Reserve Bank of India, and Federal Public Service Commission.

The Assessment of the Government of India Act of 1935

- **'Totally disappointing':** The Act was deemed 'totally disappointing' by Congress. The act was universally condemned. Jawaharlal Nehru described the Act as "a car without engines, but all brakes."
- **No mention of the Dominion Status:** It made no mention of the Dominion Status promised by the Simon Commission.
- **Provision for separate electorates:** It also maintained the provision for separate electorates, which would further divide the community. Congress has long been opposed to a separate electorate.
- **First 'provincial elections:** The first 'provincial elections' were held in February 1937 on the basis of the Act, and they conclusively demonstrated that a large majority of Indian people supported the Congress, which recorded a majority in 8 out of 11 provinces.
- **Safeguards' and special responsibilities':** Numerous Safeguards' and special responsibilities of the governor- general acted as brakes on the Act's proper operation.
- **Rigid constitution:** The Act established a rigid constitution with no room for internal growth. The right to amend was reserved for the British Parliament.

Despite criticism at the time, many of the Act's provisions were accepted by the government of India after Independence, and this act was a landmark in terms of concessions offered to Indians and reforms proposed in the governing system. In its 1935 session, Congress for the first time openly demanded the institution of a Constitutional Assembly based on adult franchise to draft the Constitution.

Elections of 1937

Jawahar Lal Nehru, Subhas Chandra Bose, Congress Socialists, and Communists were all opposed to holding provincial elections for the first time in 1937, as required by the 1935 Act. They were against the participation in elections, because-

- **Debate on Participation:** Some believed contesting elections under the 1935 Act would weaken the freedom struggle by implying Congress's support for British rule. Others felt taking office meant accepting "responsibility without power," as real authority remained with the colonial government, risking loss of the movement's revolutionary spirit since 1919.
- **Strategic Entry:** Many viewed participation as a tactical move to expose the 1935 Act's flaws from within, not an endorsement. The aim was still full independence, using legislative entry as part of a broader strategy.
- **Nehru's Campaign (1936):** Jawaharlal Nehru clarified in the election manifesto that:

1. Congress's ultimate goal remains independence.
2. It opposes the 1935 Act.
3. Formation of a Constituent Assembly is a top priority.

- **Congress Victory and Governance:** Except in Bengal, Sind, Punjab, Assam, and NWFP, Congress won majorities and formed ministries. Leaders lived modestly—cutting their salaries and using second/third class rail travel—to align with their promises.
- **Progressive Reforms:** Congress ministries introduced various reforms, passed new laws, and released political prisoners, demonstrating governance aligned with nationalist ideals.

Election Results in 1937

- **Widened the schism between the Congress and the League:** It widened the schism between the Congress and the League, and it became more communal and strident in its demand for a separate nation;

- **The League broadened its social support:** The Congress's failure to mobilise the Muslim masses in the 1930s allowed the League to broaden its social support.
- **However, Congress's performance was hampered by a number of factors, including:**
  - **Centre is more powerful:** Inherent power remained with the centre, and Viceroys and Governors had the authority to veto their resolutions; and
  - **Limited financial resources:** Congress had limited financial resources, with the Centre receiving the lion's share.
- **Elites in legislative councils:** According to the mechanism of bicameralism in provinces, in most provinces, there were 'legislative councils' that were elected on a limited franchise basis and were occupied by landlords, zamindars, and other elites.
- **Reform plans were also thwarted:** Congress's reform plans were also thwarted by vested interests.

Assessment of Congress Rule

- **Use council work to their advantage:** Even though internal strife, opportunism, and a desire for power had begun to emerge among Congressmen by 1939, they were able to use council work to their advantage to a large extent.
- **State power to advance its goals:** Members of Congress demonstrated that a movement could use state power to advance its goals without being co-opted.
- **Able to control communal riots:** The ministries were able to control communal riots, and council work assisted in neutralising many previously hostile elements (landlords, for example).
- **See the shape of things:** People could see the shape of things to come if independence was won.
- **Weakened the myth:** Indian administrative work weakened the myth that Indians were unfit to rule.
- **Raised the hopes of the industrial working class:** The massive Congress triumph in the elections had raised the hopes of the industrial working class; there was heightened militancy and industrial discontent in Bombay, Gujarat, the United Provinces, and Bengal at a time when the Congress was brought closer to Indian capitalists.

Key Words

Gandhian era, Satyagraha, Champaran, Kheda, Non-cooperation, Civil Disobedience, Salt March, Quit India, Swaraj, Trusteeship, Harijan campaign, Purna Swaraj, Round Table Conferences, Communalism, Poona Pact, Government of India Act 1935.

	Previous Year Questions	Year
1.	Bring out the constructive programmes of Mahatma Gandhi during the Non-Cooperation Movement and Civil Disobedience Movement.	2021
2.	Many voices had strengthened and enriched the nationalist movement during the Gandhian phase. Elaborate.	2019
3.	Throw light on the significance of the thoughts of Mahatma Gandhi in the present times.	2018
4.	Mahatma Gandhi and Dr B.R. Ambedkar, despite having divergent approaches and strategies, had a common goal of amelioration of the downtrodden. Elucidate.	2015
5.	It would have been difficult for the Constituent Assembly to complete its historic task of drafting the Constitution for Independent India in just three years but for the experience gained with the Government of India Act, 1935. Discuss.	2015
6.	How different would have been the achievement of Indian independence without Mahatma Gandhi? Discuss.	2014